Ideology and Terror

Chapter 13

Genesis of the Chapter

- What is the philosophical and core origin of totalitarianism in a final way?
- The book originally came out in 1950. In answer to this question, Arendt began writing this chapter, 'Ideology and Terror' in **1952** and she took a revised form of the essay "Ideology and Terror: A Novel Form of Government", first published in German as the concluding chapter to the German edition of *The Origins of Totalitarianism* and then translated in English to the concluding chapter of the English edition of the book.

Five different Arguments

There are five different arguments that Arendt is making here in this chapter:

1. It reaffirms Arendt's guiding inside which she begins at the outset of the book **that totalitarianism is new; that it is a novel government.** Thus, **it is distinct from tyranny, despotism, fascism**. A lot of what we see in the world is rising tyranny, or rising despotism, what we might call **illiberalism or illiberal democracy**. But that's not the same as totalitarianism. That totalitarianism is a novel form of government and its newness is important.

2. The second argument is **that totalitarianism seeks a fundamental transformation in the idea of humanity**. In what man is; in what humans are away from being a free actor to someone who is continually fabricated and may actualize themselves in accordance with natural and historical laws. This is the part that is not in the title; **lawfulness.** This is the idea of man made in a sense as one who must follow in a profound way without freedom, **the laws of history and nature is a key aspect of what she is interested in**. She writes an entire essay called **'Law and Power'**. It was not published in her lifetime but was published in the later years in the critical editions.

3. Insofar as man is transformed away from being a free actor into product of higher laws, totalitarian subjects are moulded to fit the laws of the movement by terror. And thus **terror becomes the essence of totalitarian domination.** It's not just means of social control as tyrants use terror for some political purpose, to suppress dissent. In totalitarianism, terror serves a different function. **It is to fully eradicate human freedom in private as well as public life.**

4. Totalitarian domination **fabricates its subjects in line with ideologies, in line with systems of thought that are logically rigid even if they remove and insulate their inherence from ideology.**

5. The most chilling and most important argument that the newness of the totalitarian movements which are secured by terror and motivated and inspired by ideology **is made possible by the fundamental and new modern experiment of loneliness**, the ever more pervasive sense of abandonment and set adrift in a world without meaning.

Novelty of Totalitarianism

- "The Earth-shattering originality of totalizing methods and organization…In both Nazi Germany and Bolshevist Soviet Russia, totalitarianism "**developed entirely new political institutions and destroy all social, legal and political traditions of the country**. Thus the drive of totalitarian domination is not simply **to pacify and control the population**, that's what **tyrants do**"
- Its not simply to let the trains run on time and **lose terror and force to introduce order in society**, that's what **fascists do** but **the goal of totalitarianism is to organize people and the guard with a single animating idea**.
- "the originality of totalitarianism is something new, and that means **it coincides in some profound way to our modern age** and if that's true she says, the dangers of totalitarianism will not disappear simply because Nazism and Bolshevism have been defeated. **It is something in the air of modernity. It is not some accidental appearance.** It will not disappear with the death of Stalin or it didn't disappear with the fall of Nazi Germany and thus, "The true problems of our times cannot be understood let alone solved, with the acknowledgment that totalitarianism became the centrist curse only **because it so terrifyingly took care of its problems**."

Totalitarianism addresses Modern Loneliness

- **The reason totalitarianism is there (it exists) is because it takes care of our problems: the problems of our center, its meaninglessness, atomization, homelessness, rootlessness, loneliness, all of which are problems of modern society** to which totalitarianism has an answer to and thus she concludes that, it may be true that the true problems of our time will assume their authentic form, though not necessarily the cruelest one that totalitarianism has become a thing of the past. Yes, it is true that totalitarianism is maybe the cruelest form of government known to man. **As a form of organized loneliness, totalitarianism is considerably more dangerous than tyranny and despotism and yet it may not be the worst.** There may be other things after it that may follow upon it that may be more or less cruel that may offer a similar solution to the problems that it tries to answer.

- If totalitarianism is a truly novel and true form of government, how did it emerge? It is rare that new forms of government emerge. According to Plato, there are six forms of government: **Monarchy, oligarchy, Aristocracy, tyranny, polity, Democracy.** Generally, these six have been adequate to for 2000 years to understand different forms of government. Kant comes up with another kind of definition: **lawful and lawless governments.** But how a brand new form of government emerge? Arendt says, **there has to be a new kind of experience that enter the world to which totalitarianism is an adequate response**. She names this new experience as **the experience of loneliness**. And what she argues is that loneliness is this new kind of experience, **a new problem of our time that makes other forms of government in some meaningful way inadequate which totalitarianism offers an adequate response**.

Laws of History and Nature

- The second argument is that **man in totalitarianism is the embodiment of the laws of a movement**. It's tempting to see totalitarianism simply as a lawless form of government or as a new form of tyranny. Totalitarianism is something radically new, where what unites all earlier forms of tyranny is the lawlessness (it is above the law). **They can change the law; they can make the law arbitrary** (461). In some ways, totalitarianism seems like a form of tyranny as it defies the positive laws and yet in its core nature, **totalitarianism is not lawless. It aims to follow the laws but different laws, mainly the laws of nature and history.** Arendt says that totalitarianism is monstrous yet far from being lawless. If tyrants can defy the law on a whim, Totalitarian rulers gained their power **by actually subordinating themselves to higher laws.** They (Hitler and Stalin) are the people who put themselves under higher laws i**n a way of bringing those laws to reality and actualization**. So in other words, while totalitarian government makes more positive laws like a tyrant, the totalitarian ruler far from being arbitrary is actually obeying higher laws thus they are more **obedient to superhuman forces than any government ever was before.** This is the novelty that, far from wielding its power in the interest of one man like a tyrant, **totalitarianism is quite prepared to sacrifice everybody including the ruler to the vital immediate interest of the law of history or the law of nature.**

- Totalitarianism has this sense of aiming **to establishing a direct rein of justice on earth** and its aiming to produce **mankind as a product of justice**, as a product of the laws of history or the laws of nature in a sense they are saying that we are going to follow these laws so strictly in order to remake mankind to be just. In that sense, It makes all laws as the laws of the movement.
- The two examples that she offered here are **Darwinism and Marxism**. Darwinism says that man is a product of natural laws; natural law-selection and development, laws of nature. These are racial laws in that they say that the race of man will keep evolving and it won't even stop with humans, it may not stop with trans-humans, with AI with humans becoming fodder for a great big machine in the future. **But these follow the natural laws of hierarchy.**
- The Bolsheviks say **that class struggle is for the expression of the laws of history for the survival of the most progressive class** and thus **Engles** says that '**Marxism is the Darwinism of history' (**which Arendt cites at 463). So in both Darwinism and Bolshevism, which she understands as ideologies **the term law itself has changed its meaning from expressing the framework of stability within which human actions and motions can take place and it becomes the expression of the motion itself. The law is the expression of the way the racial laws and class based laws actualize themselves in a claim of justice on the earth.** If you are going to do that, if you are going to realize these natural and historical laws and make man fully conform with them. **What if men do not fully conform with them or men do not conform with them?** They have freedom and they want to act differently from what the natural or the racial laws allows, **you need terror to fit man into that iron band of these laws of motion are the laws of the movement.**

Terror to realize the laws of the Movement

- The third essence of totalitarianism is that the material essence of higher laws (motion laws). Totalitarian subjects are forced to fit the mould of the movement by terror. **Terror thus is the essence of totalitarian domination.** It is not simply a means or source of control as tyrants use terror to suppress political dissent. It's much more than that. Terror becomes a tool for totalitarian rulers **to fully eradicate human freedom in private as well as in public life into thus actualize the realm of ideological justice on earth.** Thus terror is the realization of the laws of the movement. Its chief aim is to make it possible for the force of nature (in Darwinism or racism) or the force of history (in Marxism) **to race freely though mankind unhindered by spontaneous human action**: 'Terror is the realization of the law of movement; its chief aim is to make it possible for the force of nature or of history to race freely through mankind, unhindered by any spontaneous human action. As such terror **seeks to "stabilize" men in order to liberate the forces of nature or history.**" (465)
- " Terror is lawfulness, if law is the law of the movement **of some superhuman force, Nature or History.**" Terror is as **the execution of law of movement whose ultimate goal is not the welfare of men or the interest of one man but the fabrication of mankind**, eliminates individuals for the sake of species, sacrifices the "parts" for the sake of the "whole"…" (465)

- Terror is lawfulness. It is the realization of the movement or some superhuman force of nature or history imposed on reality. Terror takes these laws of history and nature and imposes them on humanity. Terror as the law of the movement serves the fabrication of mankind, the making of mankind from men, **the elimination of the individuals for the sake of the species.**
- **Terror fits men into the iron band of terror. It substitutes for the laws that are hedges protecting the space between individuals acting as hedges separating my life from your life that gives me certain amount of freedom** but terror is not like that. "It substitutes for the boundaries and channels of communication between individual men a band of iron **which holds them so tightly together that it is as though their plurality had disappeared into One Man of gigantic dimensions.** To abolish the fences of laws between men—as tyranny does—means to take away man's liberties and **destroy freedom as a living political reality;** for the space between men as it is hedged by laws, is the living space of freedom. **Total terror uses this old instrument of tyranny but destroys at the same time also the lawless, fenceless wilderness of fear and suspicion which tyranny leaves behind. This desert, to be sure, is no longer a living space of freedom,** but it still provides some room for the fear-guided movements and suspicion-ridden actions of its inhabitants. (455-56)
- By pressing men against each other, total terror destroys the space between them; compared to the condition with its iron band, **even the desert of tyranny, in so far as it is still some kind of space, appears like a guarantee of freedom.**"

- In a tyranny, terror prevents you from speaking in public but leaves you still a desert of private life where you could still be free, you can't build a public life where you could act together but you can have poetry, you can have a chess-club, a Reading group… it leaves that alone, that desert of freedom. But in totalitarianism this desert which is not really a space of political freedom but of private freedom, it still provides room for some kind of freedom for its inhabitants in a tyranny **but totalitarianism by pressing men together destroys even that freedom, it destroys the spaces between them**.

- Terror "destroys the one essential prerequisite of all freedom" which is the spaces between men. If the essence of totalitarianism government is movement, **The aim of totalitarian education is not to instill convictions in men; it's not to make them believe something** (468). **It's to bring them so close together to take away their privacy and freedom that they lose their capacities to form any convictions.**
- And if that's the case, **what makes people act in a realm of totalitarianism?** There is some sort of a craving need for some insight into the law of movement **but to act is to act in accordance with the law of movement.** And what guides **behavior in totalitarian rule is to prepare them to act on both sides: to be an executioner and a victim.** In Nazism you are prepared to be either an executioner of the race laws or a victim of them. In Marxism, you are either an executioner of the class struggles laws or a victim of them. **And what prepares you to be a victim or an executioner is ideology.**

Ideology

- Totalitarian domination fabricates its subjects in line with ideologies; systems of thought that are logically rigid even if they remove or insulate their inherence from reality.
- ”**ideologies are -isms which to the satisfaction of their adherents can explain everything and every occurrence by deducing it from a single premise”** Racism, Marxism, communism…all of reality can be understood by the idea of race, god or class, can be **explained as an-ism but these are pseudoscience.** The idea of race or class or God are actually not that important, you can put in any idea.
- **What is more important than the idea is the logic of the idea**. This is Arendt’s real innovation in understanding ideology. **The idea of ideology is not the idea but it is the instrument of explanation that follows its own logic.** So racism is the belief that of the motion inherent in the idea of *race*; deism is the belief that there is a motion inherent in the idea of *God*; Communism is the belief that there is a motion inherent in the idea of *commune*. **The actual idea of all these ideas is not the core of ideological power it is the logical deduction from premises.** There are many ideologies (environmentalism, deism, nationalism…) but what makes racism and communism totalitarian ideologies is t**hat the struggle between race and class is turned out to be politically important in such a way that Hitler and Stalin could take these ideologies with utmost seriousness** (if there are dead classes or dying classes that these classes must be killed; if there are races unfit to live then these races must be exterminated). The classes are more important than the idea. (471-72)

Three elements of an Ideology

Arendt says that there are three totalitarian elements of an ideology:

1. **An ideology explains not *what is* but *what it becomes;***

2. **It is independent of experience**. It doesn't matter if the *bourgeoise* are actually corrupt or not or if *Aryans* are a perfect race or not or if *Jews* are actually greedy or not. It has nothing to do with it.

3. **Since ideologies have no power to transform reality, you have to emancipate thought from simply focusing on the logic** (you can't actually make Jews greedy, just because you say they are) **and thus there is a consistency in ideology that exists nowhere in reality.**

- Thus ideological logic requires that we stop thinking, moving between thought and reality and **we exist purely in the realm of ideas**. In this way, **fully divorced from reality, the ideal subject of totalitarian rule is not the convinced Nazi or the convinced communist as the idea is not important or the reality is not important**. **What you need is people for whom the distinction between fact and fiction and the distinction between true and false no longer exists so that they can exist in their logical prison of reality of an ideology.**

Loneliness

- The novel emergence of totalitarian movements, secured by terror, the essence of totalitarianism, inspired by ideology which is the principle of totalitarianism is made possible by the fundamental and new modern experience of loneliness, the ever more pervasive sense of abandonment and set adrift in a world without meaning.
- We come back to **the very basic experience of living together of humans. Isolation is not the same thing as loneliness. Tyrants isolate people so they can prevent them from politically challenging them. Isolation is the beginning of terror. It is a proto-totalitarianism. But since Isolation leaves the private sphere unattacked, it's not totalitarianism.** Loneliness is something completely different. **Loneliness is being deserted of all human companionship. Totalitarianism in so far as it is a response to loneliness, destroys all private life as well. It bases itself on loneliness, on the experience of not belonging to the world at all which is among the most radical and desperate experiences of man** (475).

- Loneliness is so unbearable because **it is the loss of one's self that can be confirmed only by the company or friendship of equals.** To be a self you need other people who trust you so you can trust yourself. Without friends, others and plurality, we can't trust ourselves, we are thrust back into the only thing that we have left which is our human mind and logical reasoning (the only thing that is reliable). If we are truly lonely and there is no one who is reliable or who we can trust, **all we can base ourselves on is logic** (477).
- Arendt quotes Martin Luther who says, "**It's not good for man to be alone. A lonely man always deduces one thing to the other and thinks everything to the worst." And she writes, the famous extremism of totalitarian movements consists in this "thinking everything to the worst**". So long as loneliness remains a human experience, totalitarianism will persist as a possible form of government.

- " the crisis of our time and the its central experience have brought forth an entirely new form of government which is a potentiality and an ever-present **danger is only too likely to stay with us from now on,** just as other forms of government which came about at different historical moments and rested on different fundamental experiences have stayed with mankind regardless of temporary defeats—monarchies, and republics, tyrannies, dictatorships and despotism." (478) Those forms of governments are still around because **they also represented possibilities of experience of mankind.** But now there is new experience of mankind, loneliness the form of government that responds to it is now with us likely in perpetuity.
- **We have to understand the origin of totalitarianism in this fundamental experience of loneliness and understand that we are going to resist and face the possibility of totalitarianism**;
- we have to see **where it comes from and why it is attractive because in responding to totalitarianism** it puts man into meaning and into movements and provide for them a sense of self and identity which are increasingly unable to be found elsewhere.